be called the National Exit Test (NEXT), will be mandatory for medical students in India as well. Figures with the National Board of Examinations (NBE), which conducts the FMGE, reveal that the number of students taking the FMGE nearly tripled to 35,774 in 2020 from 12,116 in 2015. Though it is not an accurate measure of the number of students going abroad for medical education, since many of those appearing for FMGE are foreign nationals, unofficial estimates peg the number of Indian students studying medicine in countries such as China, Russia, Ukraine, Kyrgyzstan, the Philippines, Kazakhstan, Poland, Romania and Bulgaria at 25,000-30,000.



PAWAN BHAWAR

What explains this great gold rush for medical education abroad? Two things, broadly. The limited number of medical seats in India, and the prohibitive cost of medical education in the country. According to the National Medical Commission (NMC), there are 90,825 MBBS seats in India and some 1.6 million students took the NEET (National Eligibility Cum Entrance Test, mandatory to secure admission to any medical college in India) in 2021. More than half of them cleared the examination. More than 700,000 students, therefore, had the eligibility. But they did not have anywhere to go.

Others got placed in private medical colleges but did not have the money for the education. "A six-year MBBS course in Ukraine costs between Rs 32 lakh and Rs 35 lakh, which includes tuition fees, food and accommodation. In comparison, in most Indian private medical colleges, students have to pay more than Rs 1 crore in just tuition fees," says Abhinav Jha, 24, a fourth-year medical student from Jamshedpur. Hence his decision to go to Crimean Federal University in Simferopol in Crimea in Russia. Ditto for Gautam Kumar, 22, from Nawada in Bihar, who was in his fourth year at the Dnipro State Medical University in Ukraine.

Courses in many foreign countries are also less competitive than they are in India. In February 2018, NEET was made compulsory for an eligibility certificate to study MBBS even abroad. While a general category aspirant for medical education needed a minimum score of 550 out of 720 to secure admission in 2021, medical colleges in several east European countries allow admission at NEET scores as low as 138.

Critics of the centralised examination process—and there are many—allege that NEET has rendered medical education out of bounds for poor students. According to the Union health ministry, 547 MBBS seats remained vacant between 2018 and 2020. This year, the number has reached 741. "Success in NEET now depends on expensive and rigorous coaching," says Dr D. Karthikeyan, principal secretary in the department of higher education in Tamil Nadu, and a medical graduate himself. "Poor students, particularly those from the vernacular medium, who cannot enrol in high-profile coaching centres, fail to get good scores." Tamil Nadu is among the states that have registered vociferous protests against NEET.

TOO MANY PEOPLE, TOO FEW DOCTORS

The rush for a foreign medical degree cannot be more ironic in a country that has the highest number of medical colleges—605—in the world. Since 2015, 193 new medical colleges have been set up, 136 of them in the government sector. In the preceding eight years, the total number of MBBS seats had gone up by 77 per cent. In absolute numbers, India has more allopathic doctors—1.3 million—than even a developed country like the US. If you add the 565,000-odd AAYUSH doctors, the country could well have 12 doctors per 10,000 people, comfortably ahead of the WHO (World Health Organization)-mandated doctor-population ratio of 10 doctors for 10,000 people, although traditional medicine practitioners may be an iffy fit on that list.

But then we are also a country of 1.3 billion people. The discrepancy was more than evident as the Covid-19 crisis unfolded. China, by contrast, has 3.61 million doctors for its 1.4 billion people, nearly three times what India has. On a global scale too, India is among the 57 countries that face the most severe crisis in terms of